WHERE DO WE TAKE JFK?

A grounded read of `jfkairport.com` as it stands today, what peer airports do, and five directions worth weighing.

WHAT'S INSIDE

An audit of the current site (palette, type, motifs, IA, tensions), a peer-airport landscape, and five strategic directions ranging from low-risk refresh to full premium-gateway repositioning — each with risk/cost trade-offs.

DECISION NEEDED

Which direction — A, B, B+C, D, or E — is the right one to brief into a target visual system. Two convergence questions on the final page.

01 What we found

A 5-page crawl (home + four IA pillars: flights, transportation, explore-jfk, dine-shop-relax) parsed against the brand surface — palette frequency, type families, system components, voice samples, accessibility tensions.

11
distinct colors in the captured palette

2
custom-licensed type families (Sharp Grotesk + Helvetica Now)

320px
hero "JFK" wordmark — heroic-scale display

5
distinct audiences sharing one home page

Brand investment is real

Two custom-licensed type families: **Sharp Grotesk Semibold** (Lucas Sharp / Sharp Type — the same family Adobe and several Pentagram clients use) for display, and **Helvetica Now for PANYNJ** (Monotype private cut) for body. A heroic 320px "JFK" wordmark above the fold. A single vivid primary, `#0045FF`, doing the brand work. This isn't a generic template skin — someone bought the right type and committed to a confident wordmark moment.

#0045FF	#022DB7	#011565	#FFCD00	#1B7A2F	#EFF9FF	#F1FCF2	#09090B	#475569

Execution under-cashes the investment

The hero says "global brand"; everything below it reverts to a 2019-era municipal template — full-bleed photo → 52px h2 → 3-column icon-card grid → tinted alt section → repeat. The same skeleton on home, flights, transportation, explore-jfk, and dine-shop-relax. The site is recognisable as *a template*, not as *JFK*. The 320px hero gets the budget; everything beneath it gets the framework.

02 Six load-bearing tensions

Detected by rule-based scans against the per-page JSON and the consolidated brand-extraction. Each one is specific enough to brief a fix against.

`T-color-imbalance`

One hue carries every affordance

`#0045FF` appears 211 times across the sample, used identically for plain link text, primary CTAs, active tabs, and headline accents. When one color does every job, hierarchy collapses — users can't tell "navigate" from "submit" at a glance.

`T-display-body-cliff`

Heroic display, conventional body

The 320px Sharp Grotesk hero is exceptional. The very next viewport collapses to a generic 16/20px Helvetica Now grid that any 2019 municipal site could produce. The type investment is being under-cashed below the fold.

`T-template-silhouette`

Same composition on every IA pillar

Full-bleed photo → "Welcome / Discover / Get / Find" h2 → 3-column icon-card grid → cross-promo → footer. Five pages, identical skeleton. Recognisable as municipal-modernism, not as JFK.

`T-audience-collision`

Five audiences, one undifferentiated home

A panicked late traveller, a relaxed early arrival, a pickup driver during construction, a connecting passenger, and a dwell-time visitor share the same first viewport. Audience routing is implicit, not explicit.

`T-voice-distance`

No human warmth in a high-anxiety context

Airports induce anxiety. The voice is uniformly procedural — "Welcome to John F. Kennedy International Airport," "Get your essentials and more at JFK." No NYC flavour, no acknowledgment of stress. Compare with Singapore Changi (theatrical) or Heathrow (concierge).

`T-perf-and-a11y`

Editorial images 12× oversampled, alt-text mostly empty

Editorial card images are served at 1080×1440 intrinsic but rendered at 312×416 — ~12× oversampled by area. Nine of ten sampled hero/card images have empty `alt`. Real perf cost on mobile; meaningful accessibility gap.

03 How peer airports solve this

A landscape pass across the airports JFK gets compared to. Each one stakes a different posture — there's no "right" answer, but there are coherent answers and incoherent ones.

Airport	Posture	Move worth stealing
Singapore Changi	Lifestyle / theatrical	Treats itself as a destination brand, not infrastructure. Editorial layouts, integrated retail and dining stories, distinctive identity that earns dwell time. Not "an airport site"; "the Changi experience."

Airport	Posture	Move worth stealing
Heathrow	Concierge / personalised	"Your journey" personalisation, calm premium tone, deep booking funnels for parking/lounges/security fast-track. Premium feel without being aspirational.
Schiphol	Calm utility	Information density without clutter. Multilingual-native. Reads as a Dutch design product rather than a corporate site. Closest visual cousin to where JFK currently lives, but better executed.
SFO	Playful civic	Warm voice, art program elevated to brand surface, distinctive identity. Civic but human — a rare combination JFK could plausibly land.
LAX (recent)	Wayfinding-led	Strong real-time integration, branded but functional. Coral accents introduce warmth without losing the operational tone.
DXB · AUH	Premium gateway	Cinematic video heroes, dark-mode editorial, marketing-grade lifestyle content. Off-strategy for a public agency, but a useful reference point for what "premium gateway" looks like.

Where JFK currently sits

Closest to **Schiphol minus the calm** — same utility-led ambition, but cluttered with colliding audiences, a single-hue affordance system, and a template silhouette that doesn't match the type investment. The brand surface implies a more confident posture than the page composition delivers.

04 Five directions worth weighing

Each direction is internally coherent. They imply different trade-offs in cost, risk, and PANYNJ buy-in. Recommendation flagged on the right.

A Civic-confident refresh

RISK LOW | RECOMMENDED BASELINE

"The brand was right, the execution wasn't."

Keep Sharp Grotesk + Helvetica Now + the PANYNJ blue family. Fix the six tensions without rewriting the brand. Differentiate the affordance system (CTA fill ≠ link text ≠ active tab). Cash in the display family below the fold (editorial layouts on transportation and explore). Add explicit audience routing on the home page. Ship perf and alt-text fixes.

Peers	Schiphol, Heathrow (visual register)
Cost	Medium — composition rewrite per page, palette role-renaming, affordance hierarchy redesign.
Doesn't fix	Template silhouette feeling. Voice stays civic.

B New York–flavoured gateway

RISK MEDIUM

"The airport of NYC, not just in NYC."

Direction A plus: let New York editorial sensibility into the site. Editorial photography on neighborhoods, terminals, and people. Voice warms ("Welcome to New York" before "Welcome to JFK"). Type plays bigger (Sharp Grotesk gets more room, more contrast). Section sequence shifts toward "discover" alongside "function."

Peers	Changi (lifestyle-led), but NYC-tonal not Singapore-polished.
Cost	High — needs new editorial photography, new copywriting, more layout variety.
Doesn't fix	The panicked late traveller in viewport one. Could conflict with PANYNJ's "agency, not airline" reflex.

C Anxiety-first, journey-staged

RISK MEDIUM

"The product is calm."

Restructure around traveller journey stages — *Before you fly · While you're here · After you land*. First viewport is "what stage are you in?" routing, not a hero photo. Status, wait times, construction advisories, and pickup state become primary content; marketing content gets demoted. Personalisation hooks (your flight, your terminal). Layerable on top of A or B.

Peers	Heathrow's "My Journey," many transit-authority sites.
Cost	High — requires real-time data integration (security wait, pickup status, construction state).
Doesn't fix	The brand visually; could read as a "downgrade" to functional dashboard if used alone.

D Construction-era honest

RISK MEDIUM-HIGH

"The site that gets you through 2025–2028."

JFK is mid-$19B redevelopment until ~2028 — that's three years of visible upheaval. Lean into it: the site openly acknowledges "we're under construction" as the dominant editorial lens. "What's open today / what's changed / where's pickup right now" becomes the first viewport. The yellow advisory band gets promoted from band to surface.

Peers	TfL during Crossrail; emergency-response government sites.
Cost	Medium.
Doesn't fix	Time-bound — wrong frame after 2028. Brand team may resist framing as "the construction site."

E Premium gateway

RISK HIGH

"NYC deserves a world-class welcome." (Rebrand-shaped — would need explicit opt-in.)

Reposition JFK as a destination brand the way DXB / AUH / Changi do. Cinematic video heroes, dark-mode editorial sections, marketing-grade lifestyle content. Probably drops Sharp Grotesk for a more distinctive serif/grotesk pairing. Shifts register from civic to premium-consumer.

Peers	DXB, AUH, Changi.
Cost	Very high — this is a rebrand, not a refresh.
Doesn't fix	Likely off-strategy. PANYNJ is a public agency, not a luxury brand.

05 The read

An honest convergence of what the data, the peer landscape, and PANYNJ's positioning all point toward.

Recommendation: A or B, with C layered onto whichever wins.

A (civic-confident refresh) is the safe presales answer — same brand surface, fixed execution. Brand team will recognise themselves immediately.

B (NYC-flavoured) is the more interesting answer but needs PANYNJ buy-in on warmth and on letting an editorial register into a civic site. If buy-in is plausible, B is more durable.

C (anxiety-first, journey-staged) is an IA decision that can be made independently of the visual direction. Either A or B is improved by adopting C.

D and E are real options but have clear failure modes. D ages out at the end of redevelopment. E is off-strategy for a public agency and would need an explicit rebrand mandate.

Two questions to converge before we brief the spec

1. **Direction.** A (civic refresh) vs B (NYC-flavoured) vs B+C (NYC-flavoured + journey-staged IA)?
2. **Mode.** Should we keep the Sharp Grotesk + Helvetica Now + PANYNJ blue brand surface (recommended; signal is strong), or are you open to a partial palette/type move?

What happens after we agree

Once direction lands, the next step is `stardust:direct` — it produces a target `PRODUCT.md`, target `DESIGN.md`, a `direction.md` reasoning trace, and a per-page improvements list. From there `stardust:prototype` renders one or more prototype pages we can review before committing to a full migration.